June 25, 2026

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Last month, Candid's senior director of development moved on to a new opportunity. Filling her position will be no small task, given her thoughtfulness and dedication to building long-term relationships with our funders. Her departure has me stepping back into day-to-day development work alongside my team. The experience has given me a fresh wave of empathy for all fundraisers who carry this work, often just as one part of an already full plate.

When time and resources are stretched, I look for smart shortcuts. Nothing reminds me of this more than my first year at Candid. I sent 99 cold letters of inquiry. Zero landed. The one grant I did close that year—a $250,000 award that hit my entire annual target—came from an ongoing conversation. That lesson has never left me: relationships over volume, every time. Summer is the perfect time for this kind of reset. Things quiet down, and there's space to remember what actually works.

I'm also simplifying how I think about metrics. Pick the few things that actually tell you if you're on track, and watch them obsessively. Stewardship? Track those conversations. Building a donor pipeline? Keep a close eye on active solicitations, expected gift amounts, prospects, and timing. You don't have to do it all. The fundraisers I've seen thrive aren't doing more. They're doing less, better.

You're not just raising dollars—you're advocating for causes and communities you love, with less runway and more pressure than anyone acknowledges. I see you. Keep going.



Aleda Gagarin
Vice President of Influence, Candid

Your best funder is the one you already have

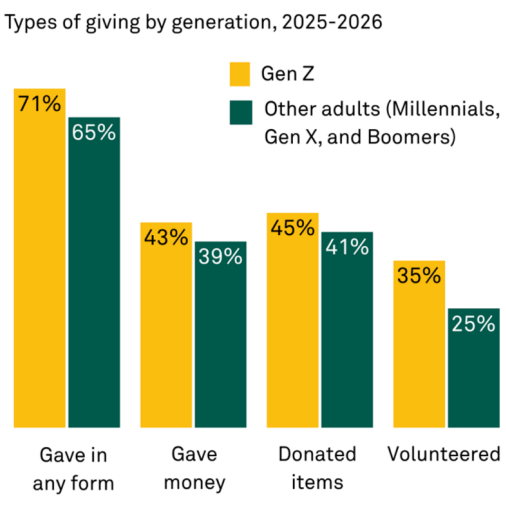
Keeping a funder who already believes in your work is far more efficient than finding a new one from scratch. In a LinkedIn Live conversation, Candid's Aleda Gagarin and Cathleen Clerkin, Ph.D., shared what actually works when it comes to building long-term relationships with funders.

One of the biggest takeaways? Don't be afraid to start a conversation!

More takeaways

Featured data: Gen Z is more generous than you think

71% of Gen Z gave in some way last year. That's higher than any other generation. In their new joint report, GoFundMe and GivingTuesday break down what the data says about Gen Z donors and how nonprofits can engage them.



Get the data

More from Candid insights

Are you tracking the right fundraising data?

More data doesn't always mean better decisions. Learn which metrics support strategic fundraising, how to decide what to track and how often, and get tips for building a strategy that works.

Find out

Donors want nonprofits to 'get out the vote'

Your nonprofit can legally get involved in election activities such as voter registration drives, candidate forums, nonpartisan voter guides, and lobbying. And according to an M+R survey, donors want you to. Find out how your organization can get voters to the polls, help volunteers sign up as poll workers, and ensure people know their rights.

Get involved

Tips for securing more DAF grants

Donor-advised funds (DAFs) are a growing source of nonprofit revenue, but many nonprofits haven't tapped into them. Vanguard Charitable grants manager Erin Carson shares advice on making sure your nonprofit is findable, credible, and how to make DAF giving easy. Spoiler alert: It starts with updating your Candid profile.

Go after DAF grants

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